

I62 Silas

The Jerusalem leader who became Paul's partner and sang hymns in a Philippian jail.

Silas was a respected leader and prophet in the Jerusalem church. After the council in Jerusalem, the apostles chose him to carry their letter to the Gentile believers in Antioch. When Paul and Barnabas parted ways, Paul chose Silas as his new partner, and together they carried the gospel into Europe. At Philippi they were beaten and locked in the stocks, yet at midnight they prayed and sang praises to God. Silas helped plant churches in Philippi, Thessalonica, Berea and Corinth, and his name stands beside Paul's at the start of two letters. Paul's letters call him Silvanus. Later he appears with Peter. He is a picture of steady, faithful partnership.

At a glance

Name	Silas in Acts; Silvanus in the letters (most take as one man)
Background	A leader and prophet in the Jerusalem church (Acts 15:22, 32)
Status	A Roman citizen, like Paul (Acts 16:37)
When	c. AD 49–52 with Paul; later with Peter
Key places	Jerusalem, Antioch, Philippi, Thessalonica, Berea, Corinth
Key people	Paul, Timothy, Barnabas, Judas Barsabas, Lydia, Peter
Main passages	Acts 15–18
In the letters	2 Corinthians 1:19; 1 and 2 Thessalonians 1:1; 1 Peter 5:12

"And at midnight Paul and Silas prayed, and sang praises unto God: and the prisoners heard them."

Acts 16:25, KJV

The life of Silas

Dates are approximate (AD) and follow Paul's second journey, c. AD 49–52.

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| c. AD 49
<i>Jerusalem</i> | <div>● Chosen by the council</div> <p>After the council, the apostles and elders choose Judas Barsabas and Silas, "chief men among the brethren," to carry their letter to the Gentile believers in Antioch. <i>Acts 15:22–29</i></p> |
| c. AD 49
<i>Antioch</i> | <div>● Prophet and encourager</div> <p>Judas and Silas, "being prophets also themselves," encourage and strengthen the believers with many words. The KJV adds that Silas chose to stay on in Antioch. <i>Acts 15:30–34</i></p> |
| c. AD 49
<i>Antioch</i> | <div>● Paul's new partner</div> <p>After Paul and Barnabas part ways, Paul chooses Silas. The church commends them to God's grace, and they strengthen the churches of Syria and Cilicia. <i>Acts 15:36–41</i></p> |
| c. AD 49–50
<i>Philippi</i> | <div>● Singing in prison</div> <p>Paul and Silas are beaten and put in the stocks after Paul frees a slave girl from a spirit. At midnight they pray and sing. An earthquake opens the doors, and the jailer believes. <i>Acts 16:16–34</i></p> |
| c. AD 50
<i>Thessalonica and Berea</i> | <div>● Driven onward</div> <p>Their preaching wins converts but stirs up a mob. Sent away by night to Berea, Silas stays there with Timothy while Paul goes on to Athens. <i>Acts 17:1–15</i></p> |
| c. AD 50–52
<i>Corinth</i> | <div>● Rejoins Paul</div> <p>Silas and Timothy arrive from Macedonia, and Paul, "pressed in the spirit," testifies that Jesus is the Christ. Silas is named with Paul in both letters to the Thessalonians. <i>Acts 18:5; 1 Thessalonians 1:1</i></p> |
| Later
<i>With Peter</i> | <div>● A faithful brother</div> <p>Peter writes his first letter "by Silvanus, a faithful brother unto you." <i>1 Peter 5:12</i></p> |

Key activities

Acts 15:34 is missing from many of the oldest manuscripts, so most modern translations leave it out. Silvanus is the longer Latin form of the name Silas.

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- 1 Carried the council's letter.** He took the decision of the apostles and elders to Antioch and confirmed it in person. *Acts 15:22, 27*
 - 2 Encouraged the church as a prophet.** He "exhorted the brethren with many words, and confirmed them." *Acts 15:32*
 - 3 Joined Paul's mission.** He took Barnabas's place as Paul's partner on the second journey. *Acts 15:40*
 - 4 Delivered the council's decrees.** With Paul and Timothy he passed on the Jerusalem decisions, and the churches grew daily. *Acts 16:4-5*
 - 5 Suffered at Philippi.** He was beaten with rods and fastened in the stocks without a trial. *Acts 16:22-24, 37*
 - 6 Praised God at midnight.** He and Paul prayed and sang while the other prisoners listened. *Acts 16:25*
 - 7 Helped the jailer believe.** They told him, "Believe on the Lord Jesus Christ, and thou shalt be saved, and thy house." *Acts 16:30-34*
 - 8 Planted churches.** He preached in Thessalonica, Berea and Corinth. *Acts 17:4, 10; 2 Corinthians 1:19*
 - 9 Helped write letters.** His name opens both letters to the Thessalonians, and Peter wrote "by Silvanus." *1 Thessalonians 1:1; 2 Thessalonians 1:1; 1 Peter 5:12*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references first. Echoes are study links; Silas is not named in the Old Testament.

Old Testament

Echo: Psalm 119:62	"At midnight I will rise to give thanks"
Echo: Psalm 105:17–18	Joseph's feet hurt with fetters in prison

New Testament

Acts 15:22–40	Chosen by Jerusalem, sent to Antioch, chosen by Paul
Acts 16:19–40	Beaten and jailed at Philippi; a Roman citizen
Acts 17:1–15; 18:5	Thessalonica and Berea; rejoins Paul in Corinth
2 Corinthians 1:19	Preached Christ at Corinth
1 and 2 Thessalonians 1:1	Named as a sender with Paul
1 Peter 5:12	"By Silvanus": helper in writing or carrier? Debated
Echo: Philippians 4:4	"Rejoice in the Lord alway," written from prison

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What did Paul and Silas do at midnight, and who was listening (Acts 16:25)?
2. *Understand:* Silas was a Jerusalem leader, yet spent years as Paul's partner. What does that show?
3. *Apply:* How could you pray or give thanks in a hard situation you face now?
4. *Apply:* Whose steady, quiet service could you thank or support this week?